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3 Law of the Land Ministry of Environment and Forests, 1985

It was a milestone in the history of the Government of India, when in 1980, the Department of Environment was given an autonomous identity. By 1985, it grew into the full-fledged Ministry of Environment and Forests. Since then it has implemented the Coastal Zone Management Plan in Gujarat and defined the terms for environmental clearance for industries.

4 Right Reservation Biosphere Reserves, 1985

"A new concept in conservation made its hesitant debut in the country," in 1985 when "the Union Department of Environment finalised the details of the Nilgiri Biosphere Reserve, the first of 12 such reserves to be set up in the country," noted INDIA TODAY in October 1985. Even though the concept was introduced 12 years after its conceptualisation in 1973 by UNESCO, today the number stands at a healthy 14 with reserves like the Sunderbans and Gulf of Mannar.

5 Watered Down Ganga Action Plan, 1985

It's a symbol of purity for many Hindus but the Ganga today is a "foul receptacle of sewage and toxic waste" (INDIA TODAY, January 1997). The authorities woke up, though belatedly, to its condition and it was in 1985 that the Ganga Action Plan (GAP) was launched—the largest clean-up operation in India worth Rs 1,700 crore. "Today the plan is a telling example of how things can go terribly wrong." It had entailed setting up sewage treatment plants, electric crematoria and toilets. "GAP has been criticised for misuse of funds, overspending and tardy progress," said INDIA TODAY in 1997, "All the stress points on the Ganga have today been found polluted because of ill-conceived schemes."



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6 Check Post Environment Impact Assessment Reports, 1982

It was in 1982 that the Government decided to put a stop to the indiscriminate concretisation by enforcing the Environment (Protection) Act. The enforcers constituted expert appraisal committees under the Environment Impact Assessment Project at the Centre as well as the state level. These were to look into matters concerning environmental flashpoints like the Sardar Sarovar Dam, the Posco steel plant in Paradip, Orissa, and the bauxite refinery project in Kalahandi.